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Masking, Authenticity, and Peer Adaptation in Gifted Children

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Background: Giftedness, peers, and the masking/authenticity problem

Gifted children often feel different from age peers, and this can make friendship and everyday peer life harder. That basic mismatch helps explain why some gifted children hide parts of themselves, while others try to stay open and authentic. (3 sources)

Giftedness can shape peer life in a basic way: many gifted children notice that they are not like the children around them, and this felt difference can make social connection harder. They may struggle to find friends who feel similar, have trouble joining peer activities that do not match their interests, and feel alienated when their social setting does not respond well to their needs. This sense of being different is not trivial; it is linked to difficulty building peer relationships, lower self-esteem, and broader social-emotional strain. In that context, the masking-versus-authenticity problem becomes easier to understand: if a child expects that showing their real interests, abilities, or intensity will increase distance from peers, masking can become a way to fit in, while authenticity can feel risky even if it is more true to self. (Karateke, 2017) (Gali et al., 2019) (Lavrijsen et al., 2023)

Evidence

(Karateke, 2017)

Social Skills Training in Potentially Gifted Children

> *"A child with superior talents may see himself different from other children, may have difficulty in establishing relationships with his/her peers, and may feel different in relation to low self-esteem. This perceptual difference can cause children to experience many social emotional problems (Morawska et al., 2009)."*

(Gali et al., 2019)

SCHOOL PROBLEMS IN THE EDUCATION AND DEVELOPMENT OF GIFTED CHILDREN: PSYCHOLOGICAL ASPECT

> *"Gifted children have difficulty with finding friends who are close in spirit, they have problems of participating in peer games that they are not interested in. The complexity of the situation is aggravated by the fact that the children realize that they are not similar to others."*

(Lavrijsen et al., 2023)

High Cognitive Ability and Mental Health: Findings from a Large Community Sample of Adolescents

> *"Others have argued that gifted children may feel different or alienated from their peers (Lein, 2021), or that the environment of the intellectually gifted youth is sometimes not sufficiently responsive to their needs (e.g., (Kanevsky et al., 2003)."*

Adaptation and masking strategies used with peers

Gifted children often adapt to peers by hiding ability, lowering visible performance, managing how they talk, or choosing social roles that reduce the risk of standing out. They may also use humor, helping, selective friendship, withdrawal, or "acting normal" to protect belonging. (13 sources)

- **Hiding or downplaying ability is one of the most common strategies.** Gifted children may try to look less advanced than they are, hide talents, pretend to know less, or stay within the achievement range of peers so they will be more accepted. This can include denying that they are gifted at all. (Rokach, 2018) (Horvat, 2019) (R et al., 2020) (Tourreix et al., 2023) (KONIK, 2023) (Kennedy et al., 2018)
- **Some deliberately underachieve or reduce visible effort.** Rather than only hiding labels, some gifted children change work habits, stop showing what they can do, miss questions on purpose, lie about grades, or otherwise "dumb down" achievement to avoid peer rejection. (R et al., 2020) (KONIK, 2023) (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019)
- **They may carefully manage speech, interests, and self-expression.** To fit classroom and peer norms, some avoid "high level" vocabulary, talk about age-expected topics, hold back unusual ideas or feelings, and think hard before saying something that may mark them as different. (David, 2015)
- **Many manage information about their giftedness rather than revealing it openly.** A repeated theme is not just "masking" in general, but active control over what others know: gifted students may reveal only parts of their ability, conform their behavior to peers, or use camouflage so they can keep more normal social space. (Tourreix et al., 2023) (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019) (Sisk, 2021)
- **Humor is a common social tool.** Gifted children may use humor to gain acceptance, cope with exclusion, connect with close friends, or shift attention away from their difference. In some cases this becomes a positive bridge; in others it can slide into the "class clown" role. (Demir et al., 2021) (David, 2015) (Tourreix et al., 2023) (KONIK, 2023)
- **Some adapt by taking prosocial roles.** Instead of hiding completely, they may help others, stay socially active, and use shared activities or homework help as a way to create safer peer ties while making their ability more acceptable. (Tourreix et al., 2023) (KONIK, 2023) (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019)
- **Withdrawal and isolation are also adaptation strategies.** When interaction feels too hard or unrewarding, some gifted children pull back from games, detach from group activities, isolate themselves, or mentally disengage through abstention and daydreaming. (Horvat, 2019) (Demir et al., 2021) (David, 2015)
- **Some respond with attention-seeking, hyperactive, or disruptive behavior.** If they are bored, unsupported, or unable to fit in directly, they may disturb class, make jokes, act out, or show frustration through disruptive behavior. This may function as a way to handle mismatch with peers and the setting, even if adults read it only as misbehavior. (David, 2015) (Demir et al., 2021) (Zanetti et al., 2024)
- **They may build alternative identities that feel more socially acceptable.** Rather than presenting themselves as openly gifted, some develop a different social persona or "protective mask" that better fits peer culture. (Sisk, 2021)
- **Selective friendship is another key strategy.** When same-age peers do not share their interests, some gifted children turn toward parents for companionship, seek out a small number of close friends who understand them, or do better in settings with similar-ability peers where they can share interests more naturally. (Horvat, 2019) (Khalil et al., 2016)
- **These strategies vary by context, including school culture and country.** Hiding and conformity are reported as common in some US and European settings, while in some other contexts, openly showing high ability may be more accepted. (Tourreix et al., 2023)

Evidence

(Rokach, 2018)

Children's Giftedness and Its Determinants

"It was found that as time passes by and they start to feel lonely and not accepted by peers, gifted adolescents hide their talents and perform within the range where their peers operate see also Kaufman, Plucker & Russell [24]."

(Horvat, 2019)

SOCIOMETRIC STATUS OF GIFTED STUDENTS IN CLASSROOM AND SUBJECT TEACHING IN ELEMENTARY SCHOOL

"According to Bailey (2007), the difficulties faced by gifted individuals are most often pressure from their peers and concern for acceptance in society. In times of adolescence and identity development, gifted individuals most often seek to conceal talent in order to better integrate with their peers. They often try to hide their talent by pretending to know less than they really do. (Robinson, 2008) interprets that in early childhood gifted children begin to attend preschools, but they are worried by the fact that their peers do not enjoy the same complex games, do not read books, and do not like games with complex rules. Faced with this problem, gifted children most often try to find a friend in their parents. (Robinson, 2008) also believes that gifted children have needs as well as their peers, but they also have needs that are understandable only to them. They need friends whom they can socialize and share common interests with. The problem arises because gifted children are much more advanced in development than their peers, so it is much harder for them to find friends who share the same interests as they do. When they become bored in a game, they most often withdraw from the game, which often causes their peers to be confused. Gifted children deal with stress in social relationships in a very unusual way. Asher and Fontaine (1990, according to Gommans, 2010) find that the influence of peer relationships becomes more important as children get into them and undergo adolescence. Numerous studies have shown that children with a negative sociometric status are more likely to show social and emotional problems. Sociometric status is also associated with loneliness. Children who have difficulties with their peers show a greater degree of loneliness and dissatisfaction (LaFontana and Cillessen, 2002)."

(R et al., 2020)

How Can We Better Understand, Identify, and Support Highly Gifted and Profoundly Gifted Students? A Literature Review of the Psychological Development of Highly-Profoundly Gifted Individuals and Overexcitabilities

"Shaklee [35] noted that highly-profoundly gifted children appeared to be in tune with their differences, and intentionally acted "less gifted" around their age-mates"

".Many of the children in Gross's [3] study deliberately underachieved for peer acceptance. The more highly gifted the child, the greater the social pressure to conform or "dumb-down" his or her achievements, thoughts, or behaviors [12,(Gross, 2000)[36][37][38]. For example, Gross [3] reported Anastasia being called melodramatic; the child recounted feeling fake, lonely, and unhappy. While she felt a sense of pride in her own work, her heightened sense of awareness made her acknowledge that she could not express her happiness; Anastasia realized that pride in one's academic success was not socially acceptable"

".Gross's [36] study found that more than 70% of early readers changed their reading habits or stopped reading altogether at school"

".Being "too different," being themselves can be "too much." Going undercover or masking their giftedness may be their best defense or protective coping mechanism (Tolan, 2018)"

".In an environment where they did not feel safe or appreciated, they might have used their abilities to camouflage and protect rather than to share and engage. These coping mechanisms, including underachievement, may lead to negative self-concept."

(Tourreix et al., 2023)

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

"There appear to be coping strategies that are specific to giftedness (Swiatek, 1995)(Swiatek, 2001), such as denying giftedness; reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance; hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors; denying importance of popularity; using humor; helping others; and engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests. These social coping strategies may vary depending on gender, social contexts, and especially the school environment. Culture also seems to have an impact on the preferential use of certain social coping strategies over others in the case of giftedness (see (Cross et al., 2009). For example, hiding conformity is a social coping strategy widely used by gifted students in the United States and some European countries, whereas this is not the case in South Korea where it is socially valued to show the extent of one's abilities"

".Research on the perception of gifted youth by their teachers and its impact on socialization yielded a surprising finding: one study (Field et al. 1998) reported that "teachers rated the gifted students as being less happy [with intellectual giftedness] than the students rated themselves". These results presumably reflect part of the social issues related to preconceptions about giftedness. This idea is described by Coleman andCross (1988, 2014) as the "stigma of giftedness". These authors detail three categories of strategies (visible coping, desertification, and/or camouflage strategies) used by gifted students to manage the information that others have about their giftedness in order to avoid this stigma."

(KONIK, 2023)

Turkish adaptation of Social Coping Questionnaire for gifted students

"Several coping mechanisms are used by students to minimize perceived social stigma, according to early studies on the stigma of giftedness (Buescher, 1985)(Coleman et al., 2014), 2000); (Coleman et al., 1993).These studies claim that gifted children try to cope with their "differentness" by underachieving (Janos et al., 1987), missing to respond to questions in class, asking questions that are not appropriate, acting like the class clown, reducing their vocabulary and lying about getting good grades, making up examinations or assignments to seem tough (Cross et al., 1995), and even denying that they are gifted (Buescher, 1985)"

". The SCQ, a 34-item self-report questionnaire, was created to evaluate the coping strategies employed by gifted kids to deal with the negative stereotypes and social pressures brought on by being recognized as gifted in a school environment"

". SCQ measures five coping styles: Denying giftedness subscale consists of 7 items, (eg."I don't think that I am gifted."Or "People think that I am gifted, but they are mistaken."),Social Interaction subscale consists of 6 items, (eg."People come to me for help with their homework.""

(Kennedy et al., 2018)

Counseling Gifted Students: School-Based Considerations and Strategies

"Gifted students may be more socially mature than their peers, which might similarly inhibit social relationships or lead students to deny or hide giftedness or achievement levels for social reasons (Reis et al., 2004)"

".some gifted students may seek to avoid, hide, or minimize their abilities in order to be more like their peers (Cross et al., 2015)."

(Carter et al., 2025)

School Experiences of Gifted Adolescents and Their Peers

"Gifted students desire normal social interactions"

".When their giftedness becomes known to others, gifted students believe that they will be treated differently"

".Gifted students tend to manage the information they reveal about their abilities to maintain a great amount of social latitude"

".Multiple studies have shown that gifted students are aware of the SGP and frequently manage the information others have about them to achieve more typical social interactions within the school environment (Coleman et al., 2014); J. R. (Cross et al., 2019)T. L. Cross et al. 1995;T. L. Cross and Stewart 1995)"

".In line with the SGP, gifted students may engage in efforts to mask their intellectual differences, particularly those that are less overtly visible (T. L. Cross 1997)"

".When individuals feel stigmatized, they may experience reductions in the levels of psychological need satisfaction (Williams and Gerber 2005). Therefore, they may attempt to use their cognitive, emotional, and behavioral resources to restore that sense of satisfaction (Mammadov 2021)"

".About one-third of the gifted students reported experiencing some degree of stigma. These students had lower teacher-student relationships ($p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.84$), weaker peer support ($p < 0.01$, Cohen's $d = 0.63$), lower social adjustment ($p < 0.01$, Cohen's $d = 0.58$), and a lower sense of belonging ($p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 0.10$) compared to other gifted students who experienced little or no stigma"

".gifted students are influenced by the way others feel about their abilities"

".gifted students feel stigmatized and that this feeling arises directly from the label of being gifted"

".students become more concerned about 'fitting in' with their peer groups (Rubin et al., 2007)."

(Cross et al., 2019)

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."

(David, 2015)

The Gifted Disabled Student in the Regular and the Special Classroom

> *"social acceptance has to do with conforming to the classroom norms, speaking about subjects considered age-appropriate, or being careful not to use "high level" vocabulary. A gifted child might find it difficult to participate in activities he or she has no interest in, not expressing feelings or ideas because they might seem odd to the peers, or thinking before using any rare or unconventional word or expression. A gifted child who is bored in the classroom might adopt behaviors such as abstention from activities, daydreaming or becoming the "classroom clown" and disturbing the teachers with voice-making, making jokes at others' expense or even at the teacher's. Such behaviors – not necessary a result of the child's giftedness but related to it – lead, in many cases, to labeling the child as "badly adjusted", "socially misfit", "isolated", or the like."*

(Sisk, 2021)

Managing the Emotional Intensities of Gifted Students with Mindfulness Practices

> *"Miraca Gross (2011) (Gross, 1998), a noted educator in gifted education from Australia, claimed that the process of identity development in intellectually gifted children and adolescents is complicated by their innate and acquired differences from age peers. To be valued within a peer culture, gifted students may mask their giftedness and develop alternative identities that are perceived as more socially acceptable. Gross called this a protective mask"*

> *".Research into the relationship between life stories and adaptation has shown that narrators who find redemptive meanings in suffering and adversity construct life stories that feature themes of personal agency and explorations and tend to enjoy higher levels of mental health, well-being, and maturity."*

(Demir et al., 2021)

Examining the Relationship between the Sense of Humor and the Social Exclusion Perceived by Gifted and Talented Students

> *"it was revealed that there was a positive relationship between the sub-dimensions of generating a sense of humor, coping through humor, and appreciating humor, which is the sense of humor sub-dimensions of gifted and talented students and the exclusion subdimension of social exclusion. This situation shows that gifted and talented children generate a sense of humor, cope with this situation through humor, and appreciate humor when they face exclusion in their social environment"*

> *". In research conducted by Ziv and Gadish (1990), it was observed that gifted and talented children take advantage of humor more because of their desire for social acceptance. When qualitative data from the same study were evaluated, it was found that the classmates of gifted and talented students do not understand them. Thus they used humor more when interacting with their close friends"*

> *". Clark's (2014) argued that gifted and talented children prefer one of three ways to respond to situations where their intellectual giftedness is not accepted and neglected. These ways are listed as isolating themselves from a group, seeking the attention of others, trying to be obedient by pleasing everyone or trying to look like everyone else. Stuart and Beste (2008) suggest that gifted and talented children perceive it difficult to interact with their peers because they are more responsive and sensitive than their classmates and are thus often seem introverted."*

(Zanetti et al., 2024)

The Influence of Gifted Children's Stress Management on Parental Stress Levels

> *"Without proper recognition and support, gifted individuals may resort to concealing their abilities to fit in with peers or, conversely, exhibit frustration through hyperactive or disruptive behavior."*

(Khalil et al., 2016)

Identifying "Good" Teachers for Gifted Students

> *"Where such a social environment does not exist, the isolation caused by feeling odd and unaccepted by peers may prevent them from achieving their potential (Burney, 2008). They may also try to conceal their skills and abilities from those around them (parents, teachers, and peers), out of the childish, yet natural, desire to feel equal to their peers and receive the same amount of attention. On the whole, research indicates that gifted children have high emotionalsocial abilities, but feelings of "not fitting in" that stem from the cognitive gap, may influence their interests and lead to difficulties in relationships with their peers (Neihart, 1999)"*

> *".The social environment plays a significant role in the learning process, and there is a greater chance that gifted students will have more significant opportunities to learn if they share their learning environment with others of similar or higher abilities, engendering a positive atmosphere that increases enjoyment, support and acceptance, and ultimately achievement."*

Effects of masking versus authenticity

Masking can help gifted children avoid standing out in the short term, but it often brings costs like stress, lower self-esteem, loneliness, and sometimes lower achievement. Authenticity can support identity, confidence, and healthier peer ties,

especially when children have similar-ability peers and adults who value them, but being authentic can also expose them to comparison, jealousy, or bullying in unsupportive settings. (10 sources)

Masking often works as a short-term social survival strategy: it can reduce visibility and sometimes make peer acceptance easier, especially for children who fear being seen as “too clever” or too different. But the research in these papers suggests that this benefit often comes with real costs. Hiding giftedness is described as stress generating, can inhibit ego or identity development, and can push children toward fake or copied behaviors that do not feel true to them; these false presentations can even backfire and lead to more rejection if the child cannot regulate the strain well. Masking is also linked to deliberate underachievement, which can directly become a barrier to achievement rather than only a social tactic. In addition, children who feel they must minimize themselves may end up lonely or isolated, may distance themselves from gifted friends, and may show lower self-worth over time. Children who feel sharply different from peers can become sadder, more worried about acceptance, and in some cases underachieve just to identify with classmates. Adult reactions matter too: pressure, exploitation, or repeated messages that a child is “too clever” can erode self-confidence and shape the child’s sense of self well into adulthood. (Gaerlan-Price, 2015) (Alexopoulou et al., 2020) (Alelyani, 2021) (Aziz et al., 2021) (Kara et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019) (Freeman, 2014)

By contrast, authenticity seems to have its best effects when the social setting is safe enough to support it. When gifted children can share interests and aspirations with peers like themselves, they cope better with negative peer pressure and are less likely to develop social problems. Support from similar others can make high achievement and social acceptance more compatible, rather than forcing a choice between them. More broadly, environments that help children recognize their values, achievements, and identity can support self-awareness, self-confidence, and the fuller expression of giftedness. At the same time, authenticity is not automatically easy or painless: in mixed peer settings, openly showing high ability can trigger jealousy, exclusion, or bullying, and gifted students are often highly aware of how their outperformance affects peers. So the effects of authenticity depend a lot on context. A useful nuance here is that same-ability settings may improve belonging and reduce loneliness, while at the same time social comparison in those settings can lower academic self-concept through the “Big-Fish-Little-Pond” effect. In other words, being able to be oneself may help friendship and acceptance, but it does not always make children feel most exceptional or academically confident. (Gaerlan-Price, 2015) (Alelyani, 2021) (Papadopoulos, 2021) (Fang et al., 2018) (Panenkova, 2022)

Taken together, the pattern is not that masking is simply bad and authenticity simply good. Instead, masking can protect belonging in the moment but often narrows achievement, identity, and well-being, while authenticity tends to be healthier when gifted children have supportive adults, affirming peer groups, and chances to connect with similar-ability children. Without that support, authenticity can feel socially costly, which is exactly why masking remains so tempting. (Gaerlan-Price, 2015) (Alexopoulou et al., 2020) (Alelyani, 2021) (Papadopoulos, 2021) (Panenkova, 2022)

Evidence

(Gaerlan-Price, 2015)

Meet, prey, like: A study of gifted girls’ interactions with social media

> *"According to Reis (2002b), many gifted and talented girls feel the pressure to conform because being gifted is seen as being different to the norm.*
>
> *Gifted girls do not want to be considered different from their friends and same-age peers. Indeed, a tendency exists for many females, regardless of age, to try to minimize their differences. For many gifted girls, however, the problem becomes more difficult as…their talents and gifts set them apart from their peers and friends. (p. 7) Kerr (1991) explains that the process of social adaptation to hide gifts and talents, which includes an "accommodating personality" and a "resourceful adaptation to the environment" (p. 140) is a barrier to achievement. Yet, Silverman (1989) suggested these traits and skills could be seen as strengths and useful for female student leaders. Silverman (2000) also believed high achievement and social acceptance need not be mutually exclusive if gifted and talented girls had "the support of others like themselves" (p. 305).*

In the quest to develop friendships with the "right" group of girls, they may "sacrifice their gifted friends" (Silverman, 2000, p. 303). Some may experience loneliness and isolation, especially if they have been rejected by their peers who may not value high achievement, or they may lack the time to develop friendships due to commitments to their work (Reis, 2002b)."

(Alexopoulou et al., 2020)

Stress, Anxiety & Mental Health Problems in Gifted Adolescents

"Coleman characterizes giftedness as a condition which places a 'stigma', therefore it may turn out as stress generating, as gifted adolescents often tend to hide it in order to enjoy acceptance from peers, according to Cross and Cross who also consider this state as an inhibitory factor towards the development of the ego (Cross et al., 2015). Grobman pointed out the difficulty of gifted adolescents to enjoy their intellectual superiority (Grobman, 2009). Many of them consider it as leading to outstanding accomplishments which devalue non-gifted peer's potential. Hence, they resort to copying behaviours which divert peer attention away from their giftedness, in order to avoid peer pressure and fulfil their need for social belonging (Cross et al., 2015). However, these fake behaviours may also lead to peer rejection when the gifted person does not have the ability of proper emotional self-regulation, which is often the case"

". The fact that gifted adolescents often receive mixed messages from peers and parents is another stress generating factor [25]. They are forced to perform outstandingly, yet at the same time, they are bullied by peers for being so outstanding. Such mixed messages and behaviours together with the fear of not living up to high parental, school or self-expectations also contribute to higher stress and anxiety levels (Grobman, 2009)(Reis et al., 2000)."

(Alelyani, 2021)

Special Educational Need of the Gifted and Talented Students in Saudi Arabia: A Review Paper

"Studies (Hollingworth, 1942;(Janos et al., 1985) discovered that children who felt themselves to be far more intelligent than their peers were more worried about being socially accepted than other gifted students"

".In such settings, gifted students feel more alone and sadder than their non-gifted peers. In an effort to identify with classmates, gifted students may become underachievers. Olszewski-Kubilius and Limburg-Weber (1999) found that academically gifted students who had peers with whom to share their interests and aspirations were better able to cope with negative peer pressure. (Siegle, 2015) validated the need for gifted students, especially the profoundly gifted, to interact with students with similar abilities. By interacting with students of like mindedness, gifted children were less likely to develop social problems."

(Aziz et al., 2021)

Exploration of Challenges Among Gifted and Talented Children

"Extreme levels of giftedness lead to isolation. Hence, in middle childhood profoundly gifted children may try to hide their abilities in the hopes of becoming more popular (Winner, 2000)"

".Despite the strength that gifted and talented children have, they also experiencing internal pressures and conflicts that limit their social and emotional development (Amnah et al., 2017)."

(Kara et al., 2025)

Cyber victimization and subjective well-being: protective roles of self-esteem and social support among Turkish gifted youths

"Previous studies have shown that many gifted children tend to conceal their talents to conform to their peers, often resulting in deliberate underachievement in academic settings (Coleman et al., 2014)(Cross et al., 2019)[76]. Bullying and cyberbullying can exacerbate this situation, leading to peer pressure and academic underperformance (Chen et al., 2020)(Chen et al., 2018)(Kara et al., 2023)(Livazović et al., 2019)"

".Additionally, gifted students are more likely to be excluded by their peers than students who have average academic abilities (Woods et al., 2004)."

(Cross et al., 2019)

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."

(Freeman, 2014)

A 35-year comparison of children labelled as gifted, unlabelled as gifted and average-ability

> *"In my study, how other people reacted to the gifted and talented made a big difference to the way the children coped with their special abilities and developed their sense of self to adulthood. A few of the gifted children were exploited for adult benefit, whether school or home, while for others, their feelings of worth were squashed for being 'too clever'. It could either take just a chance remark to affect a child's life, or the slow grind of parental pressure which could eat away at a child's self-confidence. Even very early experiences could affect the adult expression of high-level potential."*

(Papadopoulos, 2021)

Examining the Relationships among Cognitive Ability, Domain-Specific Self-Concept, and Behavioral Self-Esteem of Gifted Children Aged 5–6 Years: A Cross-Sectional Study

> *"Indeed, gifted children who feel different may display low self-esteem, as they lack the skills required to diminish the gap that exists between their intellectual and interest levels and those of their non-gifted peers"*

> *".Many of these conflicting research results regarding self-concept may be related to the educational setting in which the gifted children were placed. Zeidner and Schleyer (Zeidner et al., 1999) conducted a cross-sectional study that examined the academic self-concept, school grades, and test anxiety of 1020 gifted Israeli students attending mixed-ability classes and homogenous special classes for gifted students. They found that participants in the dedicated classes had lower academic self-concept than those who participated in mixed-ability classes. Indeed, gifted students tend to feel more confident about themselves in heterogeneous classrooms, in which they are among the most able, rather than in homogenous ability classes, in which all students have exceptional abilities and outstanding school outcomes (Marsh et al., 1984). This phenomenon is known as the "Big-Fish-Little-Pond Effect" (BFLPE); it states that able students in high-ability environments have lower academic self-concept than those students with equal abilities in lower-ability settings. That is, being a big fish in a small pond benefits one's academic self-concept. Research has demonstrated that the BFLPE is likely the result of students comparing their competence to the average ability of their peers (Fang et al., 2018). Further, research has shown that gifted children, when placed in segregated classrooms, experience less loneliness [53], have more friends (Manor-Bullock et al., 1995), and tend to perceive themselves as acceptable [55]"*

> *".Gifted children's self-concepts develop from interactions among perceptions of personal experiences and reflected evaluations, as well as from social understanding (Rayner, 2001). Thus, the development of self-concept is impacted by comparisons with peers and the characteristics of the environment in which the individual participates actively (Gagné, 2005)(Subotnik et al., 0). From a developmental and social perspective, gifted children mature in the social setting in which they live and interact with other people, including the family, and supportive networks significantly affect the individual's lifestyle, development of beliefs, and values, which can act as the foundation for the creation of the self (Casino-García et al., 2021)(Marsh et al., 1985)."*

(Fang et al., 2018)

The Big-Fish-Little-Pond Effect on Academic Self-Concept: A Meta-Analysis

> *"The Big-fish-little-Pond effect is well acknowledged as the negative effect of class/school average achievement on student academic self-concept, which profoundly impacts student academic performance and mental development. Although a few studies have been done with regard to this effect, inconsistence exists in the effect size with little success in finding moderators. Here, we present a meta-analysis to synthesize related literatures to reach a summary conclusion on the BFLPE. Furthermore, student age, comparison target, academic self-concept domain, student location, sample size, and publication year were examined as potential moderators. Thirty-three studies with fifty-six effect sizes (total N = 1,276,838) were finally included. The random effects model led to a mean of the BFLPE at $\beta = -0.28$ ($p < 0.001$). Moreover, moderator analyses revealed that the Big-Fish-Little-Pond effect is an age-based process and an intercultural phenomenon, which is stronger among high school students, in Asia and when verbal self-concept is considered. This meta-analysis is the first quantitative systematic overview of BFLPE, whose results are valuable to the understanding of BFLPE and reveal the necessity for educators from all countries to learn about operative means to help students avoid the potential negative effect. Future research expectations are offered subsequently."*

(Panenkova, 2022)

EDUCATIONAL ENVIRONMENT AS A FACTOR OF DEVELOPMENT AND ADAPTATION OF GIFTED CHILDREN

> *"The social situation of development, development of gift and adaptability of the gifted children are correlated with the formation of personal reflection and self-esteem, self-confidence, value consciousness, the formation of characterological personality traits – communication, confidence, emotional stability, self-control, and reluctance to aggression. The presented model of the adaptation process determines the conditions of the educational environment for the development and adaptation of gifted children constructive relationships in the contact social environment (gifted children, parents, teachers, peers) and educational activities that contribute to adaptation and disclosure of children's giftedness through the formation of personal qualities, self-esteem, self-awareness and self-affirmation, personal values and reflection. Awareness of personal values, their own achievements and their recognition are value determinants of the development of creative abilities and personal identity of gifted children."*

Pressures promoting masking versus authenticity

Gifted children can feel pressure to mask because being different brings social expectations, peer strain, and school demands that can flatten or "level" their giftedness. But some of the same children also develop ways to resist social pressure and hold on to a more authentic sense of self. (1 source)

A useful way to understand the pressures around masking is to see them as coming from both inside the child's experience and from the social world around them. Gifted children carry what one paper calls a "load" of uniqueness: they often face uneven development, difficulty bringing volitional control online at the right time, and strong expectations tied to being seen as special or advanced. At the same time, family, school, peer relations, and broader social support can all push their giftedness either toward growth or toward "leveling," meaning that the child's distinctness gets reduced or suppressed in the course of socialization. In practice, these pressures can work in the direction of masking: if the child reads the environment as demanding conformity, emotional restraint, or easier sameness, hiding can become the safer response. But the same account also suggests pressures in the other direction. Some gifted children develop stronger subjectivity, resist social influences, or reinterpret those influences rather than simply absorbing them, which can support a more authentic presentation of self even under pressure. Which side wins out may depend in part on how the child emotionally processes these demands, since gifted children can show especially variable emotional states that shape how they respond to school and peers. (Korneeva, 2021)

Evidence

(Korneeva, 2021)

Gifted children in the educational space

> *"The problem of preserving and developing children's giftedness in the educational space is very acute, since the peculiarities of the development of the personality of gifted children (uneven and heterochronous development of the components of giftedness as a system characteristic of the psyche and personality, the inability to timely update volitional efforts, the «load» of uniqueness and related social expectations) and the impact of social factors (family, school, relationships with peers, support from society) often leads to its leveling"*

> *".On the basis of the concept of subject regulation of educational interaction, the factors and mechanisms of preservation and progressive development of the phenomenon of child giftedness or its leveling during the socialization of gifted children in the educational space are established, in particular, the mechanism of accelerated development of their subjectivity, the mechanism of resistance to social influences, the mechanism of subjective interpretation and deformation of social influences, special variability of emotional states of gifted children, manifested in a specific transformation of the characteristics of the properties of integrative factors regulating educational interaction (IGF)."*